CHHAAVA (2025)

Maddock's first historical film—an action drama on Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj—would raise its stature, proving that there's more to it than horror comedies and small-town romances



"AS THE INDUSTRY IS THINKING, 'LET'S MAKE HORROR COMEDY', DINESH VIJAN IS NOT FOLLOWING THE PATH OF SUCCESS, HE IS WALKING ON ONE WHERE THERE ARE CHALLENGES"

LAXMAN UTEKAR
Director, *Chhaava, Mimi* and *Zara Hatke Zara Bachke*

HINDI MEDIUM (2017)

Vijan calls it a game-changer. The tale of a boutique owner (Irrfan) desperate to get his child enrolled in an English medium school tapped into the insecurities and aspirations of the middle class with humour and substance



trips. "I can't tell you the soft value of it. It is priceless." Films like *Badlapur* (2015), *Luka Chuppi*, *Zara Hatke Zara Bachke* and *Sector 36* (2024) demonstrate Vijan's affinity for stories set in a lesser-seen India. "India no longer looks to the West in an aspirational manner. We want stories about ourselves," says Vijan.

FORMULA FOR SUCCESS

Vijan admits that he isn't the most social person, but he values relationships and keeps a tight inner circle. It includes his sisters, Poonam and Pooja (both producers at Maddock); Sharada Karki Jalota, who helms creative; Ashni Parekh, who handles legal; and Homi Adajania, the director who has been with the studio since his debut film, *Being Cyrus* (2005). Vijan shuns showbiz glitz and prioritises personal life. A father to twins, he tries to reach home before they go to bed at 8 pm. He calls his wife Pramita his "lady luck"; the two tied the knot in 2018.

"Dinesh sir is focused on finding stories from our culture and history. With that, you can jump genres," says Vicky Kaushal, who acted in the Maddock hits *Zara Hatke Zara Bachke* and *Chhaava*. Also, Maddock relies on internal screenings to get feedback, with Vijan taking the lead on cutting eye-catching trailers and sitting on music sessions. The India-first outlook has empowered Vijan to consolidate his victories. *Stree*'s success emboldened him to up the budget for part II. "Do it bigger, better, madder and crazier," he says. For *Munjya*, he spent nearly 60 per cent of the Rs 45 crore budget on visual effects to develop the titular character, a vengeful, annoying spirit. By far, his biggest gamble was *Chhaava*, a Rs 200 crore budget historical action drama on Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj. "It was my biggest fear as I was navigating uncharted territory," says Vijan. The film released in February and is Hindi cinema's biggest grosser for 2025 thus far. Vijan isn't even done with 2025—up next is the romance *Param Sundari* with Siddharth Malhotra and Janhvi Kapoor; *Thama* is expected during Diwali; and there is *Ikkis*, a father-son story on the 1971 war hero Arun Khetarpal, with Dharmendra, Jaideep Alhawat and Agastya Nanda.

Maddock's stars are rising, but Vijan is aware of the testing times for the industry. "Just our films working is not enough," he says. "Among the four to five main players, there is camaraderie and conversation on how we can help increase the overall pie." Maddock has had its share of setbacks, with films like *Agent Vinod* (2012), *Raabta* (2017), *Love Aaj Kal 2* (2020) and *Roohi* (2021). Kriti Sanon, who has been associated with Maddock since Vijan's ill-fated directorial debut *Raabta*, has seen Maddock grow from a "cosy place" to a "huge building" in Santa Cruz. "He has learned from every film that hasn't worked," she says. "He analyses what he could have done differently and what didn't work in the film objectively."

Vijan isn't letting success get to his head. "I want Maddock to succeed me. So long as I am hitting it correctly, I should lead it. But at any point if I can't, I'd like to hire the guy who is better than me." For now, though, everybody wants a piece of Dino. ■



"DINESH SEES THE FILM AND ITS TRAILER IN THE NARRATION. THEN, HE IS ABLE TO SUMMARISE A FILM REALLY WELL. EACH POINT IS THERE AND IT SOUNDS GOOD. HE'S THAT SHARP"

AMAR KAUSHIK
Director, *Stree & Stree 2, Bala*